# Blog Posts

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## An Introduction to Contemporary Generational Tensions in Japanese Society

5 years ago, Japan's most prominent diaper manufacturer, Unicharm, released a report stating that their adult incontinence diapers were outselling their babies' diapers. Japan is getting older, and is facing the unenviable crisis of a rapidly shrinking population. Last year, Japan netted a population shrinkage of 310,000 (~0.98 million babies born, with a death count of ~1.3 million).

Simultaneously, Japan has experienced a rapid period of globalization, emerging from cultural and economic isolation following World War II, with a spike in industrial development and a strong set of exports, along with the end of economic wartime sanctions from the US during the American occupation.

Young Japanese growing up in a digital age, with less (but still severe) gender inequality, have upturned the traditional models of family life, and relationships in general. Long commutes for workers (including women) mean that the average worker leaves home at 5am and arrives back home sometime between 8 and 10pm, tired from standing on their feet for the past 2-3 hours while navigating their sluggish rush-hour commute. They are busy and digitally focused, becoming more adept and comfortable with virtual interaction than its meatspace alternative. Women's prevalence in modern Japanese workplaces is contributing to the death of the traditional family life. The gap between generations is the gap between traditional Japanese culture, and the rise of a new, internationally-touched millennial culture, trying to find a place for its progressive ideals in a country not culturally capable of housing them without tension. The freer, digitally minded young adults have shirked the heavy responsibility of tradition in large part. Japanese academics and psychologists say that women have become more assertive and career-minded, and men have become less aggressive, calmer, more focused on consuming media and enjoying themselves in a less hyper-masculine way. Thus, engaging in acts still deeply anchored in that leaden tradition, sex and dating chiefly among them, becomes a uniquely arduous task. In the words of many, *"Mondokusai."* "Too troublesome." Similarly, less fraught bonds with family have strengthened, and familial intimacy and happiness is on the rise,

children no longer feeling the need to rebel, bathing with parents becoming a more and more frequent occurrence (as an ordinary, non-sexual family act) and helicopter parenting (for lack of a significantly better term) becoming acceptable, even to the kids of those parents.

Japan is a chain of systems interacting in very innocent and easy-to-sympathize-with ways whose emergent outcomes are a total shift in the way Japan exists, and so much of this is centered around the generational divide as a new generation struggles to incorporate its understanding of the world as a whole with their parents' understanding of how Japan always has been in a dramatic and sudden way.

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*I recognize this blog post may be more general and less specific than requested, but I think it's necessary to understand and explicitly discuss the context within which specific parts of the contemporary generation gap in Japan exist, and that not having that context would make it far harder to discuss how each to-be-blogged-about event and notion fits into the whole of Japanese culture and history.*

# How World War II and Living Memories Informed the Generation Gap in Japan

If you had told me that as part of an English class, I'd be reading a 46-page briefing from The Center for Strategic and International Studies to the US government from 2002 about how to pursue relationships between Japan and the United States and influence Japan's growth, taking into account generational differences, I'd admittedly believe it, but I'd still be pretty shocked.

Generations everywhere are going to follow a sort of generalizable pattern where the old is replaced by the new, and the new are more malleable and willing to change (both themselves and their country / general externality). So for this post (and the rest of the posts), I wanted to dive into what unique things affect Japan's generation gap. Funnily enough, a strategic report from 2002 seems to offered an entry point.

One of the main differences between the current working-age generation in Japan (20-55ish) and the one that it's slowly pushing out (55+) is the existence of a living memory of World War II. This report specifically says that there's a difference in attitudes between those born after 1952 and those born before, and whether they did or didn't have memories of the war or the immediately-post-war period.

The report states that the older generation in Japan *doesn't want* Japan to become a competitive global superpower, economically, politically, or militarily. This has to do with the way their living memory of their state's imperialism manifests as feelings of shame and guilt over their country's war-crimes and expansionist tendencies of the past. This made me think a lot about how cultural memory works, and as an extension, storytelling, and a kind of history that isn't necessarily strictly oral or written, but an element of the collective conscious.

To elaborate, the central issue at play here isn't whether or not something was taught in schools or in books, but the living (contemporary) memory of those events, of being part of the country during that time period. While the older generation is weary of Japan growing too strong, the younger generation has hope that Japan will emerge as a competitive superpower with a strong identity, though they shy away from the word "nationalist" to define this feeling (the report explains this through how in history books and lessons following the war, nationalism was associated with most of the atrocities committed by the axis powers during the war).

It's interesting to see how nationalism and globalism intersect in this case – in part, the younger generation of Japan shirking the tradition of old may include the leaving behind of many of the beliefs and implicit ideals that separated Japan from the world. I think that as Japan continues to

push its way into the global society, and with the younger generation of Japanese now occupying positions of economic and political influence, we will continue to see Japan not only participating in the global economy, but doing so competitively, pushing its own interests with increased force.

Does the lack of emotional power of academic history (as compared to living memory) mean that as generations shift, we are doomed to repeat ourselves? In Germany, students are told that they personally were part of the reason the holocaust occurred, and that they should never come close to making similar mistakes in the future. It seems that this is an attempt to increase the duration of the nation's living memory of the atrocities they committed, to prevent similar ones in the future, but with the rise of German nationalist and neo-nazi groups, one must question how successful these efforts truly are (not that they aren't effective, but that perhaps there are diminishing returns for this sort of emotional education). Perhaps this is the reason that we never learn from history – the lessons we learn are so easily forgotten when they drift from living memory to textbooks, so quickly lose their emotional weight. I wonder if this is where oral histories succeed and textual histories begin to fail, and why the histories and parables from older civilizations were so often told with a heavy emotional bent, and further, if that's why we still remember them today.

# An Exploratory Account of Cross-Generational Trust and Youth Depression in Japan

While generational gaps have always existed throughout the world, Japan and elsewhere, the tradition of familial respect in Japan has always lessened this. Families in Japan have, for a relatively long time, lived in tri-generational households, with the middle generation taking care of both the older and the younger (a structural idea of family life called *Ie*). This structure has enabled a closeness with members of other generations, I posit, and a sympathy and cross-understanding that often eludes other cultures' cross-generational socialization. While the younger generation is getting more and more exposure to a globalist society and global-focused worldview, with a larger ability to interact with and travel to other countries, an economic downturn in the face of an aging population has pulled them back home. Honeymoon statistics, of all things, serve as a highlight of this dichotomy – compared to the older generation, contemporary newlyweds are more likely to travel abroad for their honeymoon, but less likely to stay abroad for more than just a few days before returning back to their new normal lives. Another cause often cited is the presence of the current generation of parents (referred to in citations in older blog entries as "helicopter parents") and their worries and fears about the solidity of their children's futures (even in a country where there are 125 job openings for every 100 jobseekers). Is this fear misplaced? I can't tell, and can't find many sources that clarify this, so I will make my own attempt.

These parents are used to a culture of hyper-competition in the face of prosperity (being part of a generation nicknamed the "Bubble Generation" for the fact that they graduated college during Japan's most profound economic peak). The culture perpetuated by these parents creates and fuels the self-fulfilling prophecy they most fear – that any hiccup in their children's education will leave them behind their peers, on the doomed side of an ever-widening gap. The kicker is that these parents' children were raised differently – they were told *by the educational system* that severity and normalization were not as important as being able to relax and remain creative, innovative, and to some degree individualistic (at least relative to the previous generation). They have even been dubbed "The Relaxed Generation," and in the face of this mounting pressure, this cognitive dissonance between the way they were being raised and the way they were being taught, where a certain kind of success was being expected by parents and as such, informing the contemporary culture of employment, but without the education for that specific brand of success being imparted upon them, it makes sense that they are also considered "The Withdrawn Generation," the one that has the lowest rates in years of overseas studying, the most issues with depression (about twice that of the US among certain metrics), and the highest

percentage of permanent shut-ins (*hikikomoris*). This offers another lens into the decreased sexual activity and marriage of the young generation – a sadder picture of a generation that's not just magically less interested in sex, but a generation torn apart by anxiety brought on between a disparity of parental expectation and educational upbringing, with sex being the last thing on its mind. It makes sense that people "can't be bothered" with it, a statement I used to find humorous but now find an indicator of a much deeper anxiety embedded in Japan's professional newcomers.

This matter (of Japan's youngs' waning mental health in the face of this clash between a disparate education and the heavy expectations of parents and grandparents who are a constant part of the children's upbringing) now seems far more important than my previous discussion of the incongruities between different accounts of finding jobs in the current Japanese economy, but I still feel inclined to address the latter, in the interest of some sort of closure for this blog post.

So what of this job surplus? Is it that while these jobs exist and citizens exist to fill them, they aren't good enough for the would-be workers (who might be overqualified or who expected better)? Or is it that by not filling these jobs, the economy suffers, taking each Japanese citizen with it? Could it be even that the parents expect their children to hold out for better positions, the former not feeling the brunt of the economic downturn as new entrants to the job market do?

I imagine that it must be a combination of all of these. This exploration has certainly taken a deeper, more somber turn, but I am confident now that there is much, much more to uncover, and intend to do just that.

# Further Reflections on Depression Among the Japanese Youth

On February 12, 2012, The Japan Times published an article discussing the stigma surrounding depression in Japan. Despite it being a common issue, it's been a topic few are willing to openly discuss. There's an explicit suggestion propagated in Japanese culture: Keep It To Yourself (or KITY, for short).

The article also talks about how there has been an over-emphasis on male problems surrounding employment, while women are told not to whine or nag, and to deal with their suffering and emotional burden alone.

I of course recognized that sexism was a problem in the country, but didn't stop for a minute to think how it would affect third party discourse about that country – that not everyone works, and even though more women than ever are getting jobs, there's still been a distinct lack of discussion about how to help women with depression.

*"It may be the sense of dignified self-restraint and prim respectability that compel Japanese people — particularly, as tradition has dictated, women — to de-emphasize their needs and display only the mildest forms of "proper" embarrassment. But when it comes to depression and the immense toll it is inflicting on individuals and society, it is time to abandon these shared virtues and go public." (x)*

When you live in a society that forces you to not acknowledge problems, everything is going to fall apart when those problems come to a boiling point, say, in the form of previous economic stability coming to a crash, and dealing with an authoritative structure that has, even if as in an accidental way, betrayed you.

*"And until very recently, in the face of one of the highest suicide rates in the world – three times that of the UK – the Japanese haven't had depression, either. "Suicides of resolve" have been an existential issue. Instead of depression, there has been an apparent aesthetic of melancholy (wabi-sabi)." (x)*

Imagine trying to deal with the fact that the way you were raised is antithetical to what is expected of you by the very people who raised who – people who were only willing to change part of a system, and then became dismayed by the results when everything else didn't

magically and autonomously fall into place – people who then left you behind as a failed product, and expected you to re-adapt as if this experimental education had never affected you in the first place. I posit that this has happened because of an inability to communicate in Japanese culture about certain quasi-taboo issues, including things like sex (as mentioned in anecdotes linked to by my first blog post), and in this case, depression and mental health. It's fine not to have a framework to talk about something until all of a sudden that thing needs to be handled, and this inclination to stash away problems under the rug, I think, is currently deeply hurting Japan.

# Decolonization of the Oppressors in Grossman

Grossman's essays speak deeply to the idea, present in Fanon and Sartre, of the necessity of decolonizing the mind of the oppressors (in this case, the Israeli public). Grossman reinforces this point with his calls for empathy and humanization of the other – that decolonization of the oppressor's mind means it must no longer tolerate the cognitive dissonances which it has come to accept in order to deal with the fact that it has indeed been treating people as animals – that it has been to some degree complicit in countless atrocious acts against its fellow humans.

# Generational Trends in South Korea, Some Analysis

In an effort to better understand the situation in Japan, I turned to South Korea (incidentally, the other half of my self-assigned topic that I'd ignored till now). In this blog post I will attempt to outline the issues of South Korea and relate them back to Japan.

After reviewing 9ish sources (mostly news articles (a mixture of Western and Korean), along with some academic papers), I've zeroed in three things that have generated South Korea's generational gap (which is a notable one): The political dynasty of the Parks (Geun-hye and Chung-hee), the advent of globalism (international awareness, and the rise of the internet), and the re-appearing notion of living memory, which feeds into the first two.

The election of Park Geun-hye, Park Chung-hee's daughter, was only achieved because of the increasing voter bloc of 50+ year old citizens. These citizens are still active members of the community if not active contributors to the dominant culture. But this isn't entirely by choice: with pension systems and retirement plans failing the South Korean elderly, they find themselves eager to return to work to achieve financial stability. Laws have even recently (2015) been passed to guarantee the right to work for the elderly (preventing discrimination based solely on age). Those born during and before the 1970s have a distinct memory of the economic distress faced by Korea during those times. Willfully putting aside the many civil rights abuses committed by Park Chung-hee, they remember him most for his ability to re-invigorate the South Korean economy, resuscitating it and bringing it back from the brink of death. They viewed Park Geun-hye as a revival of order and prosperity in a time where South Korea's society is making less and less sense to them, in a time where South Korea is financially suffering and lagging behind its primary trade partners (China and India) in terms of growth.

Without this particular cultural and economic living memory, the younger generation of South Koreans is aghast that their older counterparts would support another candidate from what they consider an immoral, if not outright unlawful, regime. Having grown up in a society with relatively few financial worries, they seem to have a much harder time coming to terms with what they consider a flagrant denial of democratic values, especially when Park Geun-hye was chosen over Moon Jae-in, who espoused himself as a protestor, a fighter for individual and human rights, and a champion of democracy. Indeed, the newer generation is more pro-LGBT, pro-welfare, anti-income inequality, and less interested in respecting their elders (according to a UNICEF poll). South Korea's younger citizens are less interested in taking care of their parents, and less interested in seeing a unification of North and South Korea – again, this could be chalked up to living memory – that is, the fact that younger South Koreans can't remember a

unified Korea, and are less likely to have family that live in North Korea or any kind of emotional attachment to it or sense of obligation towards it. South Korean youths are also more willing to blame the lack of Korean unification on external factors. According to the UNICEF poll previously referenced, Koreans also exhibit the largest decline in respect of elders between generations in all of Northeast Asia.

From these datapoints, we can draw out some interesting information. Living memory seems incredibly important to both South Korea's and Japan's generational gaps and changes in identity as both countries move through time. Both have been heavily affected by globalism and the internet. Both have been driven by pragmatism and a new kind of nationalism. The economics of both countries heavily influenced their generations, and South Korea was deeply influenced by the country's politics, though in my (rather limited) inquiry into Japan, I couldn't find any kind of parallel cause. This gives me more of a feeling of what conditions were unique to Japan (the educational mess-up, the depression, the sexlessness) and which conditions were more endemic to the region, the world, and generational changes as a general concept. I'm excited to look more into this.

# Conclusion

The “bubble generation”, so called because the now-older adults who belong to it graduated college at Japan’s economic peak,

and the “relaxed generation,” or “withdrawn generation,” the younger adults who are inheriting the country.

“Relaxed” because they grew up under a failed bout of experimentally lenient educational policy, ironically inspiring untold amounts of anxiety and stress over living up to the expectations of their parents without being given the resources to do so.

“Withdrawn” because of the unprecedentedly high rates of depression and permanent shut ins, and record low rates of overseas studying. Japan doesn’t officially acknowledge any of this - they claim that the numerous suicides are ones of “resolve,” not depression or pain.

Some say that Japan is dying out, and, admittedly, the country’s population trends aren’t exactly cheerful. With these unaddressed mental health issues, and work days typically lasting from 5am to 9pm when commute is taken into account, it’s no wonder that fewer and fewer people are having children. Besides, especially as Western virtues and values find their way into the country, the last thing young people want to do is engage in behavior, like courting, dating, sex, marriage, that ties them to tradition. Instead they work.

As always, it’s more complicated than a simple gap between generations. Japan is a cultural ecosystem adapting to new species, trying to find its new equilibrium as the major players change, and the attitudes of those players come and go with them.

As Japan comes down from its post-war economic boom, and the traditions that gave it its nation-state identity are eroded by overseas cultural influence and trends towards globalism, the youth of Japan must fight for a new identity for Japan, one that can co-exist with the rest of the world in the information age. One that can be a source of pride for the young citizens of the country over the coming decades, a Japan that isn’t like the rest of the world and a Japan that isn’t like the country of their childhood.